

Toward a bivalent dyadic morality

Explaining asymmetries between harm and help

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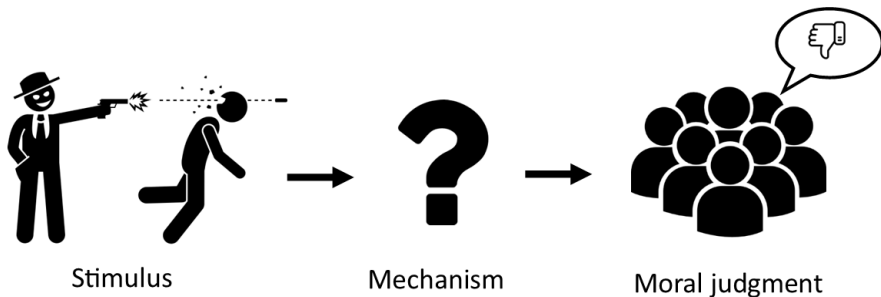
Valence Asymmetries seminar

Outline

- 1 Introduction
- 2 The theory of dyadic morality
- 3 What about help?
- 4 The biological ground
- 5 Conclusion

1. Introduction

Moral psychology



Moral psychology

- **The content of moral judgment:** What is moral judgment about?
What range of stimuli triggers moral judgment?

Moral psychology

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- **The mechanisms of moral judgment:** How do people process moral information? How is moral judgment generated?

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→ unconvincing evidence
- ② Moral judgment is *undefinable* (Stich 2018, Sinnott-Armstrong and Wheatley 2014)
→ epistemic laziness? Theoretical disadvantages

Some caveats

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- **Prototypical features of morality:** probabilistic, inherently fuzzy, no strict logical definition
- **Descriptive aim:** no “authentic” or “normatively legitimate” meaning of morality

Theoretical payoffs

- Accurate predictions of what people judge as moral or immoral
- Illuminating the processes underlying moral judgment
- Clear marking criteria for distinguishing moral from non-moral (prudential, aesthetic, epistemic) judgments
- Clarifying the biological (evolutionary) function of moral judgment

2. The theory of dyadic morality

The template comparison mechanism

Cognitive template

Synthetic construct that blend the most typical features of members of a category (Rosch 1978, Schein and Gray 2018).

Example: Bird = wings, feathers, flying, beak

- If an object matches most features in the template, it is categorized as a family member (e.g., chicken, penguin, robin)
- If an object does not match the template, it is not recognized as a family member
- The categorization can be more or less automatic along a continuum depending on the number of similarities (e.g., cow vs. whale as mammals)

Dyadic morality (Schein and Gray 2018)

Theory of dyadic morality (TDM)

Moral judgment is generated by intuitive perception of harm.

The harm template: an interaction between two minds

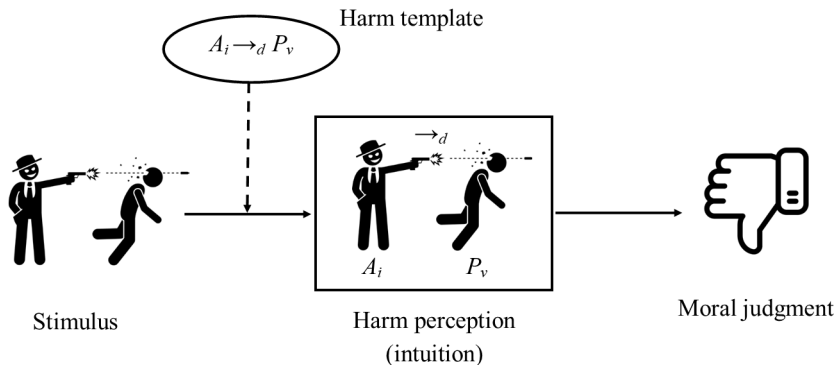
An intentional agent causing damage to a vulnerable patient.

The dyadic elements (or components)

- **Agency**: perception of a mind capable of intending and planning (intentionality)
- **Patiency**: perception of a mind capable of suffering (vulnerability)
- **Relationship**: causal link between the agent and the patient (causality)

Core prediction: increasing the salience of each element increases the perception of immorality (Schein and Gray 2018, 49).

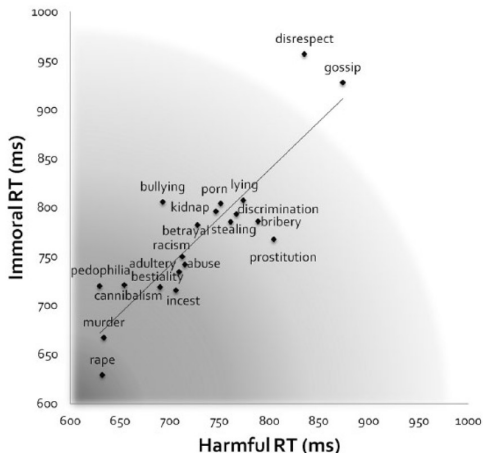
Moral judgment as a categorization



Intuitiveness of harm (Schein and Gray 2018)

Prototypical harmful acts are:

- more quickly judged as immoral
- more accessible
- more fluently judged as immoral



Disagreement about harm

Diverging ascriptions of dyadic components drive moral disagreement:

- **Intentionality:** Are individuals under compulsion or addiction morally responsible?
- **Vulnerability:** Is the fetus a vulnerable being?
- **Causality:** Is committing harm morally worse than harming by omission?

Theoretical payoffs

- **Monism:** Morality is about one single concept (pace Moral Foundation theory)
- **Single processing:** categorization by template comparison (pace dual process theory)
- Linking moral judgment to event perception (actor-action-recipient)
- Morality is reduced to basic evaluations of the environment

3. What about help?

The challenge from bivalence

Moral judgment is *bivalent*.

Harm (and *harm avoidance*) hardly explains positive moral judgments:

- moral praise of supererogatory acts
- fair benefits distribution
- praise of benevolence
- praise of sacrificial acts (harming for a greater good?)

Extending TDM?

- 1 Is positive moral judgment caused by perception of *help*?
- 2 Is positive moral judgment based on the same dyadic mechanisms as negative moral judgment?

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The help template (1)

An intentional agent causing **benefit** to a vulnerable patient.

The moral asymmetry challenge

Growing empirical evidence shows that harm and help perceptions are not mirror images, but exhibit several asymmetries (Anderson, Crockett, and Pizarro 2020; Guglielmo and Malle 2019):

- Helpers are identified differently than perpetrators (agency)
- Helpful actions are evaluated differently from harmful actions
- Help recipients may be identified differently from harm victims (patency)

Asymmetries in agency evaluation

- **Intentionality (harm) vs. Character (help)**

Perpetrators, more than helpers, are evaluated through their level of intentionality (wanting, planning, desiring, etc.) (Guglielmo and Malle 2019)

Helpers, more than perpetrators, are evaluated through character cues (emotional engagement, effort, motives) (Erlandsson, Wingren and Andersson 2020)

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- **Individual (harm) vs. Collective (help)**

People tend to blame specific individuals for harm, while they tend to praise larger groups for help (Schein et al. 2019). E.g., specific team members are blamed for a team's failure, the whole team is praised for the team's success

Asymmetries in action evaluation

- **Scope insensitivity (harm) vs. Scope sensitivity (help)**

People are more sensitive to the magnitude of caused benefit than they are to the magnitude of caused damage (Tan et al. 2025, Li et al. 2025). E.g., stealing 500 cans = stealing 400 cans; donating 500 cans > donating 400 cans

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- **Action/omission effect (harm) vs. No action/omission effect (help)**

Action-omission effect is present in judgments of harm scenarios, while it is missing in judgments of help scenarios (Bostyn and Roets 2016). E.g., letting some hostages escape = actively freeing them; drowning a child > not rescuing a child

Asymmetries in patency evaluation?

- Not well documented
- **Vulnerability (harm) vs. Needs (help)**
Harm victims tend to be evaluated through their capacity to suffer (consciousness, vulnerability), while help recipients tend to be evaluated through their capacity to growth (needs, flourishing, development) (my conjecture)

The dual process explanation (Tan et al. 2025)

Hypothesis

Negative moral judgments → intuitive, affect-based, type 1 processing

Positive moral judgments → reflective, reason-based, type 2 processing

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- Negative events exert greater emotional influence than positive events
- Negative moral judgments are more amplified (Guglielmo and Malle 2019)
- It explains asymmetries in scope sensitivity

The dual process explanation: Criticisms

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- Help scenarios elicit strong positive emotions (gratitude, admiration, joy of giving) (Västfjäll and Slovic 2020)
- Inconsistent evidence for the "amplified blame" hypothesis (Guglielmo and Malle 2019)
- Explanatory gap: Why is harm more emotional than help?

The dyadic explanation

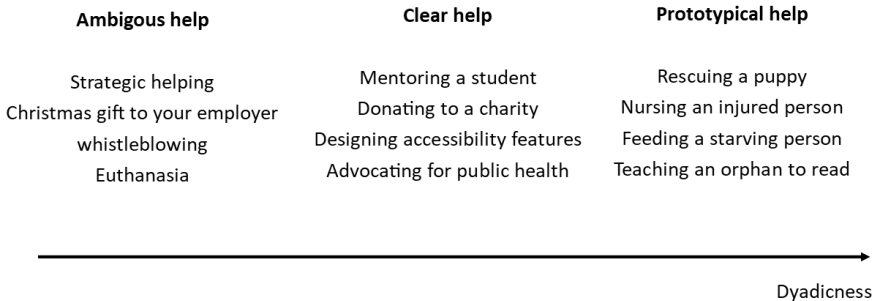
Positive and negative moral judgments are based on the same intuitive processing (template comparison), but are based on different dyadic templates (harm vs. help).

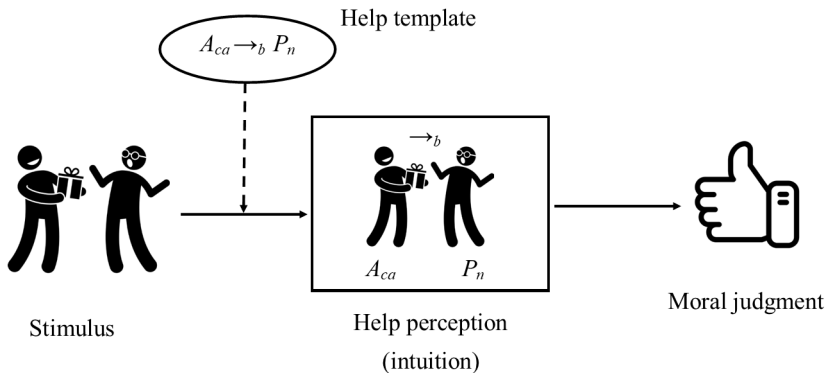
Both harm and help perceptions have a dyadic structure, but are sensitive to different types of information.

	Agency	Patiency	Action
Harm	Intentionality	Vulnerability	Causality
Help	Character	Needs	Impact

The help template (2)

An agent, motivated by care, effectively contributes to the satisfaction or development of a patient's needs





4. The biological ground

- Why is moral judgment naturally attuned to harm and help?
- What's the evolutionary function of moral judgment?
- How to explain harm/help asymmetries from an evolutionary perspective?

Morality as cooperation

Morality-as-cooperation

Morality has emerged in human evolution to offer cultural solutions to recurrent problems of cooperation (Curry, Mullins, and Whitehouse 2019).

Across evolution, humans have developed traits adapted for fostering cooperation, including a capacity to recognize and evaluate cooperative behavior of others.

The function of moral judgment

If morality has the function to promote cooperation within human society, moral judgment is the cognitive tool by which cooperative (uncooperative) behavior is classified.

Cognitive systems evolved to represent actions as 'harm' or 'help' because these representations tracked long-term cooperative payoffs.

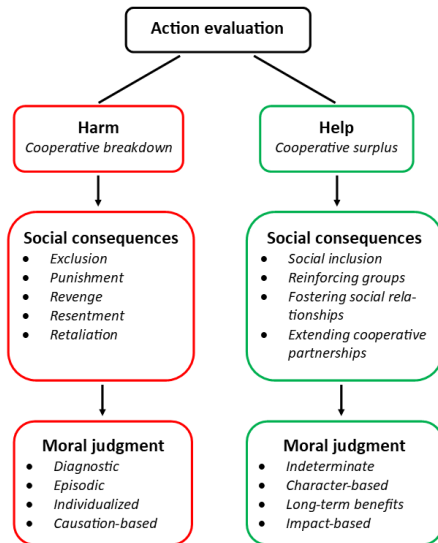
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- **Harm** → action that undermines or disrupts cooperative relations
- **Help** → action that strengthens cooperative relations

Explaining the asymmetries



5. Conclusion

Wrapping up...

- The dyadic template for *harm* should be complemented by a dyadic template for *help* to account for the bivalence of morality

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Wrapping up...

- The dyadic template for *harm* should be complemented by a dyadic template for *help* to account for the bivalence of morality
- Asymmetries between positive and negative judgments do not entail distinct processing but can be explained through a bivalent dyadic framework
- Harm and help perceptions (i.e., moral judgment) have complementary roles within the broader cooperative function of morality.

Thank you for the attention!